

Chapter 26: Distance That Doesn't Feel Like Distance

Austin's absence didn't feel like absence.

That was the problem.

It felt structured.

Like a pause that had already been accounted for.

Jenny hated how quickly she adjusted to it.

The restaurant was still the same.

Noise.

Heat.

Orders.

Bao talking too much.

Madam Chen watching everything like she always did.

But something had shifted anyway.

Not around her.

Inside her.

"You're quieter today," Bao said.

"I'm working."

"You always say that when you're thinking about him."

Jenny stopped wiping the counter.

"I'm not thinking about him."

Bao raised an eyebrow.

"You just paused mid-sentence."

Jenny resumed wiping.

Harder.

"Stop talking."

But Bao didn't stop.

"He said he'd be back."

"I know."

"And you believe him."

Jenny froze again.

"...He always comes back."

"That wasn't what I asked."

Jenny didn't answer.

Because she didn't want to.

By the third day, the silence changed shape.

It wasn't empty.

It was waiting.

Jenny noticed it in the small things.

The way she looked toward the door without meaning to.

The way she slowed when passing table seven.

The way she kept expecting a voice that wasn't there.

She hated all of it.

Because it wasn't dramatic.

It was subtle.

And subtle things were harder to fight.

On the fourth day, Madam Chen spoke to her.

"You're distracted again."

"I'm fine."

"You're not," the older woman said calmly.

Jenny sighed.

"It's just work stress."

Madam Chen looked at her for a moment.

Then said,

"It's him."

Jenny immediately shook her head.

"No."

Madam Chen didn't react.

That silence was worse.

Jenny looked away.

"He's just away for a few days."

"And you're waiting," Madam Chen said simply.

"I'm not waiting."

Madam Chen raised an eyebrow.

Jenny hesitated.

That hesitation gave her away.

The older woman sighed softly.

"You don't look like someone who is not waiting."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because she didn't know how.

On the fifth day, Jenny finally admitted something silently to herself.

The restaurant felt smaller without him.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

Like space had rearranged itself around his absence.

And now that he wasn't there...

She noticed how much space he had taken without asking.

That realization annoyed her more than anything.

Because it meant he mattered.

More than she had planned.

More than she had controlled.

On the sixth day, the bell above the door finally rang.

Jenny didn't look up immediately.

She didn't need to.

She already knew.

Still, she turned.

Austin stood there.

Same presence.

Same calm.

But something about him felt... re-centered.

Like distance had not weakened him.

Just reset him.

Jenny exhaled before she could stop herself.

"You're back early," she said.

"Yes."

That was all.

No explanation.

No justification.

Just fact.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Meeting done?"

"Yes."

She studied him.

"...That's it?"

Austin nodded once.

Jenny narrowed her eyes.

"You didn't even say anything else happened."

A pause.

Then quietly—

"Nothing important happened."

That made her stop.

"...Nothing important?"

Austin looked at her.

"You were still here."

Silence.

That landed too simply.

Too directly.

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

She turned away slightly.

"That's a ridiculous way to measure importance."

"I know," he said. "But it's mine."

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"You're impossible."

"I've been told."

A pause.

Then she added quietly,

"You didn't have to come back so fast."

Austin stepped closer to the counter.

"I wanted to."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"You always say that like it's enough reason."

"It is."

A beat.

Then softer—

"For me."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because the truth was...

It was starting to be enough.

That evening, he stayed longer than expected.

Not seated.

Not distant.

Just there.

Standing near the counter like it was now normal.

Jenny eventually asked,

"You're not going?"

"I will."

"When?"

"When I've reminded myself I'm still allowed to stay."

Jenny blinked.

"...That sounds dramatic."

"It's not," he said.

"It is."

A faint pause.

Then almost a smile.

"Maybe a little."

Jenny shook her head slightly.

"You've changed."

Austin looked at her.

"Yes."

She hesitated.

"...Because of me?"

A pause.

Then honestly—

"Yes."

That answer should have overwhelmed her.

It didn't.

It steadied her in a strange way.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

But this time...

It didn't feel like escape.

It felt like adjustment.

And for the first time...

His absence hadn't broken anything between them.

It had only made her realize it was still there.